

DISCUSSION ACTIVITY

Sponsor Decision Forum

What Should the PMO Protect?

Duration: 20 minutes | Format: structured class debate | Evidence: position and final judgment

Discussion challenge. The Smart Campus project is late, over budget, and facing a database-integration failure. There is no perfect response. Your task is to defend one recovery priority, question competing proposals, and revise or confirm your judgment after hearing evidence from others.

1. Learning Outcomes

By the end of the forum, students will be able to:

- state a clear project-recovery position;
- support claims using schedule, cost, scope, quality, and risk evidence;
- ask constructive questions and respond to counterarguments;
- compare the consequences of competing stakeholder priorities; and
- reach an individual final judgment after considering peer perspectives.

2. Evidence Available to Everyone

Project evidence		Current situation
Deadline		Pilot required at the end of week 12; current time is week 8.
Budget		Approved budget is USD 40,000; spending is already above the week 6 plan.
Progress		Actual progress was 38% when planned progress was 50%.
Quality		Twelve critical bugs were open; integration failure now blocks live data.
Essential scope	pilot	Secure login, course schedules, and essential notifications.
Optional scope	pilot	Room reservations, complaint workflow, analytics, and visual customization.
Team condition		Technical staff report overload and increasing rework.
Main uncertainty		The complete effort needed to stabilize integration is not yet known.

3. Choose an Initial Position (2 minutes)

Select one position before the discussion begins. You may change your position later, but you must explain why.

- ☐ **Position A – Protect the deadline:** freeze optional scope and deliver a smaller reliable pilot in week 12.
- ☐ **Position B – Protect the complete scope:** request a later deadline so all promised functions remain in the first pilot.
- ☐ **Position C – Protect scope and deadline through investment:** request additional budget for focused integration expertise.

- ☐ **Position D – Protect the approved budget:** retain current resources and accept a reduced scope or later completion based on a new forecast.

My initial position: _____

My strongest supporting evidence:

The stakeholder most helped by this position: _____

The stakeholder or objective placed most at risk: _____

4. Discussion Rules

1. Critique ideas and evidence, never the person presenting them.
2. Use the structure **claim** → **evidence** → **reasoning**.
3. Do not repeat a previous point unless you add new evidence or a different implication.
4. Before disagreeing, summarize the previous speaker's point fairly.
5. The goal is not to win. The goal is to improve the quality of the project decision.

5. Forum Sequence (15 minutes)

Round 1 – Opening positions (4 minutes)

One representative for each position gives a maximum 45-second statement:

“The PMO should _____ because the evidence shows _____. This protects _____, although it risks _____.”

Record one strong point from a position different from yours:

Round 2 – Evidence questions (4 minutes)

Ask questions that expose assumptions or missing evidence. Useful prompts include:

- What evidence supports your forecast?
- Which stakeholder accepts the consequence of this choice?
- What happens if integration takes longer than expected?
- How does your proposal protect quality and security?
- What exact sponsor approval does your proposal require?

Question I asked or wanted to ask:

Most useful answer heard:

Round 3 – Counterargument and response (4 minutes)

Complete both statements:

A reasonable objection to my position is:

My evidence-based response is:

Round 4 – Final vote (3 minutes)

Vote again after hearing the discussion. The final vote is individual; consensus is not required.

☐ Position A

☐ Position B

☐ Position C

☐ Position D

6. Final Judgment

My final position: _____

Did my position change? Why or why not?

The most persuasive evidence or argument was:

The sponsor decision I would request is:

7. Discussion Assessment

Criterion	Observable evidence	Points
Clear position	States a specific, relevant recovery priority.	3
Use of evidence	Uses project data rather than unsupported opinion.	3
Reasoning	Explains consequences and recognizes trade-offs.	3
Dialogic participation	Listens, questions, and responds constructively.	3
Final judgment	Revises or confirms the position using ideas from the discussion.	3
Total		15

8. Instructor Facilitation Notes

- Display or distribute the shared evidence before students choose positions.
- Place students by initial position, then alternate speakers across positions.
- Ask quiet students to contribute a question before allowing a second contribution from frequent speakers.
- Do not announce one universally correct answer. Evaluate the evidence, assumptions, trade-offs, and requested sponsor decision.
- Close by distinguishing **discussion** from **collaboration**: this forum improves individual judgment through exchanged perspectives; the collaboration exercise requires a team to produce one shared recovery briefing.

9. Responsible AI Boundary

Students must form an initial position before using AI. If permitted, AI may generate a counterargument that students critically evaluate. It may not vote, invent project evidence, or replace peer discussion. No personal or confidential information may be uploaded.